THE TEMPLE OF KNOWLEDGE

CALCism: Five-Stage Reading Pathway

An organised route from critical foundations to advanced synthesis

Guiding principle
“No theory is sacred enough to override reality.”

This is a curated sequence, not a compulsory canon. Read in order where practical, but revisit, skip or compare works according to your background and interests. The stages move from methods of inquiry to social analysis, political traditions, institutional practice and philosophical synthesis.

How to use the tables
Each row gives the catalogue title, author, reading level, publication year and reason for its position. Reading levels are editorial estimates, not formal prerequisites. Editions and publication details can vary; check the catalogue and seek lawful editions.

Reading method
For every book, note: (1) its central claim; (2) its evidence and assumptions; (3) who benefits or bears the costs if applied; (4) a serious objection; and (5) what evidence would change your view.

Stage 1 — Foundations: Critical Thinking and Social Inquiry

Purpose: Build habits of evidence-based inquiry before adopting a political framework.

No.	Book and author	Level	Why read it here
1	**How to Lie with Statistics** Darrell Huff 1954	Beginner	Spot misleading statistical presentations.
2	**The Demon-Haunted World** Carl Sagan 1995	Beginner	Practise scepticism, evidence and intellectual humility.
3	**Calling Bullshit** Carl T. Bergstrom and Jevin D. West 2020	Beginner	Evaluate data claims and information manipulation.
4	**The Art of Statistics** David Spiegelhalter 2019	Beginner	Reason about uncertainty and evidence.
5	**The Sociological Imagination** C. Wright Mills 1959	Beginner	Connect individual experience to social structures.
6	**Fragments of an Anarchist Anthropology** David Graeber 2004	Beginner	Explore political possibilities beyond state-centred assumptions.
7	**The Dawn of Everything** David Graeber and David Wengrow 2021	Intermediate	Question simple narratives about inequality and states.
8	**The Elements of Moral Philosophy** James Rachels and Stuart Rachels 1986	Beginner	Map ethical arguments before evaluating them.
9	**Mutual Aid: A Factor of Evolution** Peter Kropotkin 1902	Beginner	Introduce cooperation as a social and evolutionary theme.
10	**The Conquest of Bread** Peter Kropotkin 1892	Beginner	Begin with a foundational statement of anarchist communism.

Stage checkpoint: Summarise the strongest argument, the best counterargument, and what evidence could change your view. This is a foundation, not a loyalty test.

Stage 2 — Power, Class, Economy and Inequality

Purpose: Study institutions, economic arrangements, social identities and historical power. Compare traditions rather than treating one author as final authority.

No.	Book and author	Level	Why read it here
1	**The Communist Manifesto** Karl Marx and Friedrich Engels 1848	Beginner	A short historical statement of class struggle and communist politics.
2	**Socialism: Utopian and Scientific** Friedrich Engels 1880	Beginner	A classic introduction to Engels's socialist theory.
3	**The Two Souls of Socialism** Hal Draper 1966	Intermediate	Distinguish emancipatory socialism from socialism imposed from above.
4	**The Wealth of Nations** Adam Smith 1776	Advanced	Read a foundational account of markets and political economy critically.
5	**Doughnut Economics** Kate Raworth 2017	Beginner	Consider social needs within ecological limits.
6	**Governing the Commons** Elinor Ostrom 1990	Advanced	Examine evidence about communities managing shared resources.
7	**Seeing Like a State** James C. Scott 1998	Intermediate	Study how state simplification can misread complex societies.
8	**A People's History of the World** Chris Harman 1999	Intermediate	A broad, explicitly interpretive history from below.
9	**The Black Jacobins** C. L. R. James 1938	Intermediate	Study revolution, slavery, colonialism and Haitian independence.
10	**The Wretched of the Earth** Frantz Fanon 1961	Advanced	Analyse colonial domination and decolonisation.
11	**Feminism Is for Everybody** bell hooks 2000	Beginner	An accessible introduction to feminism and structural power.
12	**Transgender History** Susan Stryker 2008	Intermediate	Explore histories of transgender movements and communities.

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Stage 3 — Socialism, Communism, Anarchism and Workers' Self-Management

Purpose: Compare social ownership traditions, with particular attention to bottom-up self-management versus centralised authority.

No.	Book and author	Level	Why read it here
1	**Principles of Communism** Friedrich Engels 1847	Beginner	A concise question-and-answer introduction to communism.
2	**The Civil War in France** Karl Marx 1871	Intermediate	Marx's analysis of the Paris Commune.
3	**Critique of the Gotha Programme** Karl Marx 1875	Intermediate	A short influential discussion of post-capitalist distribution.
4	**Communism and Anarchy** Peter Kropotkin 1901	Beginner	Compare communist aims with anti-authoritarian organisation.
5	**The ABC of Communist Anarchism** Alexander Berkman 1929	Beginner	A plain-language introduction to anarchist communism.
6	**Anarchy** Errico Malatesta 1891	Beginner	A compact introduction to anarchist ideas and social change.
7	**Anarchism and Other Essays** Emma Goldman 1910	Beginner	Essays on freedom, authority, education and social life.
8	**What Is Property?** Pierre-Joseph Proudhon 1840	Intermediate	A historically influential critique of property relations; read with context.
9	**The Federative Principle** Pierre-Joseph Proudhon 1863	Intermediate	Explore federation and decentralised political organisation.
10	**Anarcho-Syndicalism** Rudolf Rocker 1938	Intermediate	Trade unions, direct action and worker self-management.
11	**Workers' Councils** Anton Pannekoek 1946	Advanced	An advanced account of council-based self-management.
12	**The Russian Revolution** Rosa Luxemburg 1922	Intermediate	A revolutionary socialist critique of authoritarian tendencies.

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Stage 4 — Communalism, Ecology, Feminism and Institutions

Purpose: Move from political theory towards institutions, ecological limits, care, federation and practical collective decision-making.

No.	Book and author	Level	Why read it here
1	**Post-Scarcity Anarchism** Murray Bookchin 1971	Intermediate	Connect technology, ecology and anti-authoritarian organisation.
2	**The Next Revolution** Murray Bookchin 2015	Intermediate	Introduce libertarian municipalism and communalism.
3	**The Ecology of Freedom** Murray Bookchin 1982	Advanced	A demanding study of hierarchy, domination and ecological politics.
4	**The Cooperative Commonwealth** Laurence Gronlund 1884	Intermediate	A historical proposal for cooperative social organisation.
5	**The People's Republic of Walmart** Leigh Phillips and Michal Rozworski 2019	Beginner	Discuss planning and coordination at large scale.
6	**Another Now** Yanis Varoufakis 2020	Intermediate	Explore a contemporary fictional alternative to capitalist institutions.
7	**The Second Sex** Simone de Beauvoir 1949	Advanced	A foundational, advanced work in feminist philosophy.
8	**The Making of the English Working Class** E. P. Thompson 1963	Advanced	Study class as a historical process and collective formation.
9	**The Art of Not Being Governed** James C. Scott 2009	Advanced	Explore state avoidance and Southeast Asian histories.
10	**The Presentation of Self in Everyday Life** Erving Goffman 1956	Intermediate	Understand interaction, social roles and everyday institutions.
11	**The Social Construction of Reality** Peter L. Berger and Thomas Luckmann 1966	Advanced	An advanced account of how social knowledge is produced.
12	**The General Idea of the Revolution in the Nineteenth Century** Pierre-Joseph Proudhon 1851	Advanced	A challenging extension on social and political transformation.

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Stage 5 — CALCism Synthesis: Materialism, Religion, Philosophy and Further Study

Purpose: Bring the strands together without treating CALCism or any theory as immune to criticism. Compare naturalistic inquiry, moral philosophy, religious traditions and their critics.

No.	Book and author	Level	Why read it here
1	**The Structure of Scientific Revolutions** Thomas S. Kuhn 1962	Intermediate	Examine scientific change, paradigms and the history of science.
2	**Cosmos** Carl Sagan 1980	Beginner	Place human history and inquiry within a scientific cosmic perspective.
3	**The Origin of the Family, Private Property and the State** Friedrich Engels 1884	Advanced	Read a historically influential theory alongside later scholarship.
4	**Capital, Volume I** Karl Marx 1867	Advanced	Advanced political economy; attempt after introductory economics.
5	**The German Ideology** Karl Marx and Friedrich Engels 1846	Advanced	Advanced materialist social theory; read with historical context.
6	**God and the State** Mikhail Bakunin 1882	Beginner	An anti-authoritarian critique of religious and political authority.
7	**Why Buddhism Is True** Robert Wright 2017	Intermediate	A contemporary psychological interpretation, not a neutral survey of Buddhism.
8	**Buddhism Without Beliefs** Stephen Batchelor 1997	Beginner	A modern secular interpretation to compare with traditional and scholarly sources.
9	**Buddhism: A Very Short Introduction** Damien Keown 1996	Beginner	A compact scholarly orientation to Buddhist traditions.
10	**Tao Te Ching** Laozi c. 400 BCE	Beginner	Read a translation alongside scholarship; interpretations vary.
11	**The Righteous Mind** Jonathan Haidt 2012	Intermediate	Consider psychological explanations of moral and political disagreement.

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After Stage 5 — Continue as an independent researcher

Use the full catalogue to pursue specialist paths in feminism and queer theory, comparative religion, religious movements and high-control groups, history, ecology, science, economics, psychology and other subjects. For religious traditions and organisations, distinguish primary texts, insider accounts, ex-member testimony, investigative reporting and peer-reviewed scholarship. A source may be valuable without being neutral; compare evidence and avoid generalising from an institution to every adherent.

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